

Count the deal-breakers

By Jason Rigolli — Founder, Revved for Growth · <https://fixyourrevenueengine.com/insights/count-the-deal-breakers/>

TL;DR. If your team can't recite the three deal-breakers in your qualification call, your problem isn't sales talent. It's that your ICP never left the slide deck, so every rep you hire inherits a filter that doesn't exist. Ask four people in your org to name the three deal-breakers. Four different answers tells you something bigger than a sales problem. The count doesn't fix your revenue engine; it tells you whether you have one.

Founder has an offer letter drafted for his third sales lead in two years and wants a gut check before he sends it. Ten minutes in I put the offer letter aside: name the three deal-breakers in your qualification call.

Long pause. He names two. One of them is a wish.

The next morning I ask his VP Sales the same question and get a different two.

That conversation doesn't end with a hiring decision. It ends with a harder question than the one he brought, because the problem was never the last two sales leads, and it isn't going to be fixed by the third.

If your team can't recite your three deal-breakers, your problem isn't sales talent. Your ICP was never integrated into the day-to-day (never left the slide deck), and every rep you hire inherits a filter that doesn't exist.

An ICP nobody can recite isn't a profile; it's a wish.

One thing up front: the count is not the fix. It's an instrument reading on your whole revenue engine; qualification just happens to be the cheapest place to take it. Hold that thought.

The four-answer problem

Run the test in your own org. Ask four people to name the three deal-breakers in your ICP qualification call: your sales leader, your best rep, your newest rep, and you.

Four matching answers means your ICP is operational. It lives in the calls, in deal review, in the way a rep decides whether the second meeting deserves to exist.

Four different answers, or four shrugs, means your ICP is aspirational. It lives in a positioning deck from two years ago, and nobody takes it into a live call.

That founder had a beautiful ICP slide. Revenue band, target industries, buyer titles, a paragraph on the psychology of his ideal buyer.

Careful work.

And none of it had ever been translated into the three conditions that kill a deal in the first conversation.

So every rep improvised a version, and deals that should have died in call one were dying in month three, after the demo, after the proposal, after the discount that still didn't close them.

No sales hire fixes that. It's just an expensive way to learn your ICP was never finished.

Why the next hire inherits it

Qualification discipline can't be documented into existence; that's the smart pushback. A-players qualify by instinct. Hire reps who have already sold to your ICP, and the deal-breakers take care of themselves.

The instinct part is true. I've watched a great rep kill a bad-fit deal six minutes into a first call and move on without a second thought. But instinct is individual pattern recognition, not an organizational filter. It's a cousin of the [Founder Magic I wrote about last month](#): real, valuable, unwritten, and gone the day its owner walks out the door. When the A-player leaves, the filter leaves with them. The new rep inherits the slide, not the call.

Hiring better is renting the filter. Naming the deal-breakers is owning it.

That's why the offer letter couldn't fix anything on its own. His last two sales leads didn't wash out because they couldn't sell. They inherited a pipeline full of deals that should never have entered it, spent two quarters working them, and got managed out over the results. The third was about to inherit the same thing.

Write them into the room

We held the offer letter for two weeks. Not to rethink the hire...to give the hire something to inherit.

Naming the three deal-breakers took one working session and two arguments. Writing them into the room took a month: into the qualification call structure, into deal review, into a weekly pipeline meeting kept separate from the general team call on purpose, where the first agenda item is which deals hit a deal-breaker and why they're still in it.

The count bought that founder visibility, not a fixed engine. Four different answers about deal-breakers meant nothing in his revenue engine was written into the room. The handoff criteria lived in one head. The pricing exceptions lived in another. The renewal triggers lived in his. Qualification wasn't the disease; it was the symptom that showed first and cost the least to check.

The first 30 days looked worse on paper. Deals died earlier, so pipeline shrank. He let it. Those deals were already dead; he'd been paying to find out slowly. Forecast accuracy improved because the pipeline stopped lying, not because the engine was finished. The handoffs, the pricing rules, the renewal rhythm: that work was still ahead. Now it had a map.

The new sales lead walked into the start of a system instead of a blank slide. Same territory as his predecessors. Different inheritance.

Run the count

Ask four people in your org to name the three deal-breakers in your qualification call. Four matching answers is a good sign, about qualification and usually about the rest of your engine too; discipline that shows up in one room tends to have siblings. Four different answers tell you something bigger than a sales problem.

The count doesn't fix your revenue engine. It tells you whether you have one. That's why it's the first reading I take in a Revenue Engine Inspection: it predicts what the rest of the inspection finds.

An ICP nobody can recite isn't a profile; it's a wish. Count the deal-breakers before you count on the new hire.

Run the count this week, then [send me your number](#). Worst case, you learn your engine is in better shape than most. Best case, you just found the reason the last two quarters didn't add up.



About the author — Jason Rigolli

Founder, Revved for Growth · Fractional CRO

Jason Rigolli fixes the reason a company isn't hitting its number. A two-time co-founder with three CRO seats and over two decades rebuilding revenue engines, he works inside founder-led, family-owned, and PE-backed B2B firms (\$2M–\$15M) across winning, keeping, and growing customers.

fixyourrevenueengine.com · linkedin.com/in/jasonrigolli